

MANCALA · VARIANT 7 OF 8

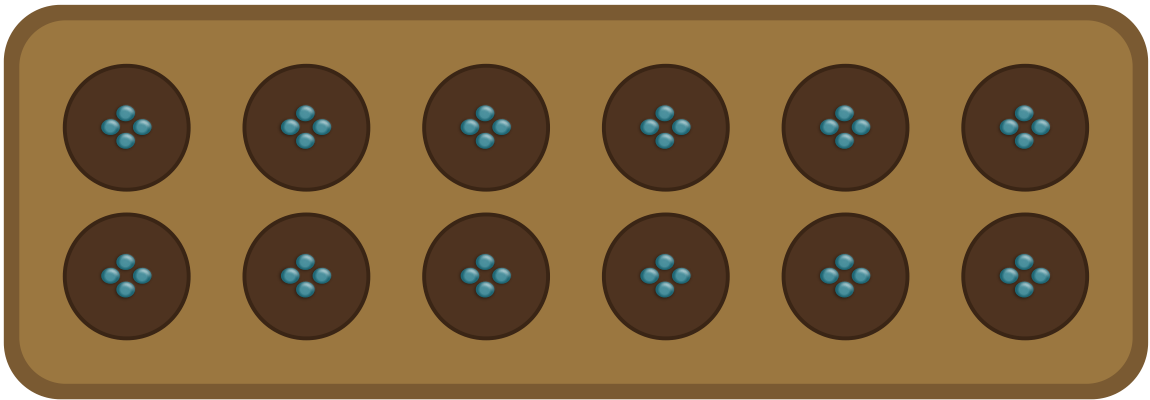
# Ayo

**2×6 pits**  
BOARD

**2**  
PLAYERS

# Ayo

The Yoruba name for the Oware family of Mancala games, played in Nigeria and among Yoruba communities worldwide. The game is culturally significant in Yoruba tradition — historically associated with philosophy, divination, and social ritual — though the rules are functionally identical to Oware. The cultural framing and terminology are distinct: seeds are called *ayo* beads, and the board (*opon ayo*) is carved with traditional motifs.



Ayo — starting position

<https://engine.moddable.games/play/?game=mancala&variant=ayo>

| ITEM  | QTY | NOTES                                        |
|-------|-----|----------------------------------------------|
| Board | 1   | 2 rows of 6 pits                             |
| Seeds | 48  | 4 seeds ( <i>ayo</i> beads) per pit at start |

## SETUP

48 seeds distributed equally, 4 per pit. No stores — captured seeds are held separately. Each player owns the 6 pits on their side.

## RULES

- Sowing:** Pick up all seeds from any one of your six pits. Sow counter-clockwise, one seed per pit, skipping the original pit if the circuit returns to it.
- Capture:** If the last seed lands in an opponent’s pit and that pit now contains exactly 2 or 3 seeds, capture those seeds. Continue capturing backwards through consecutive pits that also contain exactly 2 or 3 seeds.
- Grand slam:** If sowing would capture every seed on the opponent’s side, the move is illegal. You must choose a different pit. If no legal move avoids a grand slam, all opponent seeds remain and your turn ends.

**Feeding obligation:** If the opponent has no seeds, you must play a pit that gives them seeds. If no such move exists, the game ends and you take all remaining seeds.

## END OF GAME

The game ends when one player has more than 24 seeds, when fewer than 4 seeds remain on the board and both players agree, or when a position repeats. Remaining seeds go to the player who owns those pits.

## WINNING

The player with more captured seeds wins. 25 or more seeds wins outright.

## ATTRIBUTION

Ayo. Traditional game, Yoruba people, Nigeria. Public domain. Source: Wikipedia (CC-BY-SA); Russ, Laurence — *The Complete Mancala Games Book* (1984).